The Road Not Taken

The big idea

Robert Frost, the American poet, describes a traveller who stands where a road divides in a **yellow wood** and must choose one path. The two roads stand for **choices in life**. We cannot try every option, our choices shape our future, and we often look back on them with mixed feelings.

Summary, stanza by stanza

1. In an autumn wood, two roads diverge. The traveller is sorry he cannot travel both, so he stands a long time looking down one as far as he can see, to where it bends into the undergrowth.
2. He takes the other road, which seems to have a better claim because it is **grassy and wanted wear**. Yet he admits that both were actually worn about the same.
3. That morning both roads lay equally covered with leaves that no step had trodden black. He keeps the first road "for another day", though he doubts he will ever come back, because one way leads on to another.
4. He imagines that **"ages and ages hence"** he will tell this story **"with a sigh"**: two roads diverged, he took **the one less travelled by**, and that has **made all the difference**.

Poetic devices

Device	Example
Metaphor (extended)	The **roads** = choices in life; the **wood** = the world/life's journey

Device	Example
Imagery	"yellow wood", "grassy and wanted wear", "leaves no step had trodden black"
Personification	the road "wanted wear"
Repetition	"And looked down one... Then took the other"; "ages and ages"
Inversion	"long I stood"
Enjambment	lines run on without pause, e.g. stanza 1

FORM

Four stanzas of five lines (quintains). Rhyme scheme **ABAAB**, e.g. wood / both / stood / could / undergrowth.

Themes and message

- **Decision-making**: life presents choices; we must choose and accept consequences.
- **Individuality**: choosing the less-travelled path suggests courage to be different.
- **Regret and reflection**: the "sigh" can show nostalgia, satisfaction or regret; Frost leaves it ambiguous.

THE ROADS WERE NOT VERY DIFFERENT

Students often write that one road was clearly untrodden. The poet says they were "really about the same"; the difference lies in how we later describe our choices.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why did the poet feel sorry? Why did he choose the second road? What does "that has made all the difference" mean? Identify the rhyme scheme and a metaphor.

Quick recap

- Two roads in a yellow wood = choices in life.
- He took the "less travelled" road and it shaped his life.
- ABAAB, extended metaphor, imagery.

Practice questions

1. Who wrote "The Road Not Taken"?
   (a) William Wordsworth (b) W. B. Yeats (c) Robert Frost (d) James Kirkup
2. The "yellow wood" suggests that the season is
   (a) spring (b) summer (c) autumn (d) winter
3. Why was the poet sorry?
   (a) He could not travel both roads (b) He had lost his way (c) Both roads were blocked (d) It was getting dark
4. What is the rhyme scheme of each stanza?
   (a) ABAB (b) AABB (c) ABCB (d) ABAAB
5. The roads in the poem are a metaphor for
   (a) careers only (b) travel plans (c) choices in life (d) friends
6. Why did the poet doubt he would come back to the first road?
   (a) It was dangerous (b) One way leads on to another, so we rarely go back (c) He disliked it (d) It was closed for repairs
7. What does the poet mean when he says, "I took the one less traveled by, / And that has made all the difference"?

Answers: 1. c 2. c 3. a 4. d 5. c 6. b 7. see notes